

CALL FOR TRUCE: Hazarika (extreme right) in Amarpur; Gogoi (below)

UB PHOTOS

THE STRUCTURE

ULFA has now been left with only 1,500 cadres

7th Battalion

Area: Responsible for defence of GHQ
Status: **Defunct**

8th Battalion

Areas: Nagaon, Morigaon, Karbi Anglong
Status: **Defunct**

9th Battalion

Areas: Golaghat, Jorhat, Sibsagar
Status: **Defunct**

11th Battalion

Areas: Kamrup, Nalbari
Status: **Defunct**

27th Battalion

Areas: Barpeta, Bongaigaon, Kokrajhar
Status: **Dormant**

28th Battalion

Areas: Tinsukia, Dibrugarh
Status: **Declared ceasefire**

109th Battalion

Areas: Garo Hills, North Bengal, Dhubri
Status: **Active**

709th Battalion

Area: Kalikhola
Status: **Active**

"IF WE CANNOT PROTECT THE EXISTENCE OF ASSAMESE IN ASSAM." MRINAL HAZARIKA, ULFA LEADER

"AND OTHER ANTI-INDIA FORCES." TARUN GOGOI, CHIEF MINISTER, ASSAM

talks with the Centre. Interestingly, on the very next day of Hazarika's release, Hiranya Saikia, a controversial pcc member, was arrested for his alleged involvement in the activities of the outfit. Saikia's arrest holds significance as he is believed to be Barua's trusted link between media and the Government.

The Bravo company of the 28th battalion, which has about 150 cadres, is not part of the unilateral ceasefire. Jiten Dutta, commander of the now disbanded Alpha and the Charlie companies, claims that Chinese was initially a part of the ceasefire declaration. "In a meeting attended by Chinese, Bravo company commander Sujit Mohan, and I decided to declare the ceasefire.

But Mohan and Chinese backed out at the last moment," says Dutta.

Apart from Bravo, other three battalions—27th, 709th and 109th—have also remained silent on this ceasefire. According to the home department, the Alpha and Charlie companies have 350 members active in the state, while 700 members are functioning under the command of the other three battalions. Another 300 militants are camping in Bangladesh and Myanmar.

The state police believe that soon other battalions of ULFA will also tread the path of peace. "Leaders like Sasha Choudhury, Raju Barua, who are part of the other battalions, are gradually distancing themselves from their chief.

For now, they have adopted a wait and watch policy," says Khagen Sharma, IGP (Special Branch), Assam Police. Commenting on the two separate bomb blasts in Kumarikata, a remote village bordering Bhutan, and Nagaon, within a week of the ceasefire declaration, Sharma says that violence may increase as a desperate Barua may try to put a show of his strength. ULFA, however, has denied any involvement in the blasts.

The ceasefire declaration by the strongest crack unit of ULFA is surely a welcome move in the insurgency-ridden state, but for now, the Government faces the challenge of consolidating on the gain and taking things to the next level—the start of peace talks. For that to happen, it must successfully bring other ULFA battalions in its fold. ■